

Qn 11. Is it possible to eradicate discrimination against those who are different?

KEY TERMS

'Eradicate' -Completely remove

'Discrimination'

-The **unfair or prejudicial treatment** of people and groups, based on some ascribed or perceived trait or traits they possess. This can manifest itself either in action or speech. Such treatment would invariably end up causing those discriminated against to generally have a poorer outcome in life, or at least have some life chances robbed off them, such as access to higher levels of education and jobs that are well paying enough.

'those who are different'

** The question is not about discrimination per se but the context ('against those who are different') is critical in the discussion.

- Essays can discuss lines of **difference based on characteristics such as race, gender, or sexual orientation, special needs individuals and how and why such differences become social fault lines**, on which a society's rewards are accrued to, or withheld from individuals. This is the case in **especially societies where there is a dominant, majority group, and a relatively powerless minority group** who are outnumbered when it comes to decision-making and the distribution of resources.

POSSIBLE STAND

In many societies, despite efforts put into reducing discrimination against individuals and groups who are different, instances of prejudice and bias still persist due to entrenched systems and processes, such that in the foreseeable future, it is not possible to eradicate it.

APPROACH

- A. Cite the reasons why it is claimed that discrimination against those who are different can be eradicated, due to efforts put in by governments and other bodies to address the root causes of discrimination and how there is some progress towards removing discriminatory practices due to these efforts.
- B. Argue that while progress has indeed been made on many fronts, completely removing discrimination against those who are different in a society remains an impossible feat due to the continued existence of systems and processes that perpetuate discriminatory practices.

ARGUMENTS

- A. Cite the reasons why it is claimed that discrimination against those who are different can be eradicated, due to efforts put in by governments and other bodies to address the root causes of discrimination and how there is some progress towards removing discriminatory practices due to these efforts.

A1. Actions/measures currently taken – legislation, and policies put in place by various governing bodies are seen to have yielded some results for many forms of discrimination against those who are different, and across many locales.

-In places like the US, laws like The Civil Rights Act, the Age Discrimination in Employment Act, and the Americans with Disabilities Act, prohibit discrimination in employment on the basis of race, sex, ethnic origin and disabilities, have allowed many members of the minority groups in the US to be able to enjoy equality of treatment. They thus can go on to take on roles and responsibilities that were previously only accessible to the white American. Prominent instances of this happening span from the elections of the first African-American President Barack Obama and of Michelle Wu, the first Asian American mayor of Boston, to India-born Satya Nadella being given the reins to Microsoft in 2014.

-Since 2013, the United Nations has undertaken to tackle the discriminatory treatment of members of the Lesbian Gay Bisexual Trans-sexual Intersex (LGBTI) communities in the world through the UN Free and Equal Campaign, a global public education campaign aimed at creating awareness of the rights of the members of the communities, and to improve the life chances of the members of the group. Amongst the many achievements of UNFEC, the access to HIV/AIDS treatment by members of the community is often cited as an example of how actions and measures are successful in reducing discrimination against those who are different.

<https://www.ipinst.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/02/A-UN-for-All.pdf>

A2. Social and political activism has created enough awareness of prejudice and the need to put a stop to various systemic forms of discrimination, or at least have reduced the occurrence of various forms of discrimination against those who are different.

The eventual dismantling of apartheid in South Africa through the actions of Nelson Mandela and the improvement of the lives of African American through Black Lives Matter (George Floyd Justice in Policing Act) come to mind in this regard. The institutions and systems that discriminated against the minorities in both instances have been dismantled after much wrangling by all parties, in the form of long drawn negotiation and in some tragic instances, even violence in the form of riots and protests but for many of those who are not of the mainstream, much more rights and freedoms have been made available to them as a result of activism.

<https://www.history.com/news/end-apartheid-steps>

<https://www.dosomething.org/us/articles/black-lives-matter-protests-whats-been-achieved-so-far>

B. Argue that while indeed progress has been made on many fronts, completely removing discrimination against those who are different in a society remains an impossible feat due to the continued existence of systems and processes that perpetuate discriminatory practices.

B1. Discrimination against individuals belonging to less advantaged ethnic groups is so deep-seated and internalised in many different locales and communities that efforts to prevent it from happening are only working partially and in tokenistic ways.

- Power structures continue to exist to perpetuate discrimination, and become obstacles to truly removing the latter. In the case of the African-Americans, even though the Black Lives Matter movement that arose in the aftermath of widespread police brutality against African-Americans had no doubt seen major improvements in policing, government and education

associated with them, the main decision makers in the US are still the white American, who oversee the bulk of the governing institutions in the US.

<https://blogs.lse.ac.uk/usappblog/2022/08/15/the-limits-of-white-liberal-antiracism-mean-that-combatting-structural-racial-inequality-must-be-about-building-power-not-sympathy/>

<https://www.nytimes.com/article/what-is-critical-race-theory.html>

B2. In many societies, powers-that-be are still upholding and pandering to the views of the majority in its decision- and law making, in order to maintain political harmony and status quo, so much so that the rights of those who are different in one way or another are being swept aside.

-Even though worldwide, the rights of the LGBTI community have seen a tremendous improvement, with many countries decriminalising same-sex marriages, amongst the many forms of liberalising, there are still a significant enough number of countries that have allowed the tyranny of the majority to happen. Singapore's law criminalising sex between two males, Section 377A, is seemingly poised to be dismantled after many centuries of its existence in the country, potentially removing a main cause of discrimination of homosexuals but whether the Singapore community at large, long held to be conservative changes its views about the minority group remains to be seen. The mixed signal the government sends out, in the form of a concurrent decree that marriage has to be between a man and a woman, does not help. In fact, as recently as August 2022, a Hwa Chong Institution staff made derogatory comments about the LGBTQ community, surely a telling sign that the journey to eradicate discrimination of this form is going to be long drawn.

<https://www.bbc.com/news/world-asia-62628494>

B3. For those who are different from the norm, while institutional discrimination is no longer so apparent, there exist still instances of day-to-day discrimination such as being treated as less capable or intelligent, receiving poorer service at stores or restaurants, being treated with less courtesy and respect.

Still prevailing attitudes fail to have individuals and the community recognise that their words and deeds are discriminatory in nature. The Us versus Them mentality will forever be present as long as new ways of defining/ categorising lines of differences, making any kind of measures or campaigns always not effective. Such day-to-day discrimination frequently comes in the form of "microaggressions" such as snubs, slights and misguided comments, that suggest a person does not belong or that invalidate his or her experiences. At the very worst, it could be being treated with more suspicion by law-enforcement forces, like how the French of Arabic or Asian origin have to endure.

<https://www.france24.com/en/20200610-black-and-treated-as-such-france-s-anti-racism-protests-expose-myth-of-colour-blind-republic>